

"From 2012 to 2016, Nadal hit 30 per cent of his first shots after his serves from inside the baseline. But each year he has worked with Moya, that number has risen, first to 36 per cent, then to 39 per cent, then to 41 per cent, and last year to 42 per cent. Why is that so important? Because when Nadal hits that first shot from inside the baseline, he wins 74 per cent of the points. When he hits the first shot from behind the baseline, he wins just 59 per cent."

Despite debilitating injuries, Nadal managed to win eight more Grand Slam titles from 2017 to his last dominating year in 2022, when he seemed almost superhuman at the Australian and French Open. Neither chronic foot pain nor the effects of COVID in the previous six months stopped Nadal at Melbourne where he fought back from a two-set deficit to outlast Daniil Medvedev for the title. At Roland Garros, he needed injections to numb foot pain for the entire fortnight to conquer four top-10 players, including Djokovic, Alexander Zverev, and Casper Ruud.

Mr. Nice Guy

Sports mottos like 'Nice guys finish last' and 'Winning isn't everything; it's the only thing' never applied to Nadal. Before the sporting world knew much about him, they quickly warmed to the exuberant yet mature teenager. As the respected *ESPN* analyst Mary Carillo pithily observed, "He acts like a man out there. But he reacts like a boy. And that's why people like him."

His popularity soared as people learned more about the Spanish youngster in unconventional attire — pirate pantaloons and colourful sleeveless shirts — and noticed his acts of kindness on and off the court.

A tennis philanthropist, he launched the Rafa Nadal Foundation in 2010. It has improved the lives of thousands of children through a wide range of programmes, such as the NETS project (Nadal Educational Tennis School) in India, the 'More Than Tennis' meetings (where athletes with intellectual disabilities gather from schools across Spain), the opening of foundation centres in Palma, Valencia, and Madrid, charity



End of an era: The 38-year-old bid adieu to the sport in the 2024 Davis Cup, where he played the final match of his career, losing to Dutchman Botic van de Zandschulp in straight sets.

races, 'Play All' for socially vulnerable children, and 'Study&Play.'

In October 2018, Nadal opened his tennis academy to victims of flash floods seeking shelter in Mallorca and donated \$1.4 million to those affected. He partnered with Federer to donate \$250,000 towards Australian bushfire relief in January 2020.

The two superstars' exhibition match — held before the largest crowd in tennis history in Cape Town, South Africa, in February 2020 — attracted 51,954 fans and raised \$3.5 million for the Roger Federer Foundation.

Nadal's affection and compassion for his longtime rival and close friend were never more evident than during Federer's poignant retirement

ceremony at the 2022 Laver Cup. As both giants of the sport wept, they held hands to comfort each other. It marked the end of the iconic 'Fedal' rivalry, but the memories will endure.

"I'm very proud to be part of his career in some way," Nadal said. "But even for me, I'm happier to finish our career like friends after everything we shared on court as rivals." Two years later, Nadal retired during the Davis Cup in Málaga, Spain, and two legends of the fabulous Big Three are now gone.

"There is so much to respect about Nadal, but what I respect most is the respect he had for the game, and for the athletes who played it," Carillo said. "Nadal changed the sport for good and with manifest goodness, and that is a legacy in and of itself."